

Idiopathic Head Tremors in Dogs

What are they?

Idiopathic head tremors are **involuntary, rhythmic head movements** that start and stop on their own:

- Up and down ("yes-yes")
- Side to side ("no-no")
- Circular

They are **benign** — not seizures, and not painful.

Which dogs are affected?

Most common in **Bulldogs** (English and French), **Doberman Pinschers**, **Labrador Retrievers** and **Boxers**; mixed breeds also (about 17%). Average age at onset is about **3 years** (range 3 months–12 years).

What you may notice

- Episodes usually last **1–3 minutes** (seconds to hours)
- Your dog stays **fully alert and aware**
- Often happen at rest
- **Distraction usually stops the tremor** — treats, toys or commands
- Stress may trigger episodes

Diagnosis

Based on breed, age, history and the typical appearance — especially that your dog is alert and can be distracted.

Video recordings are very helpful. Sometimes blood tests or MRI are recommended to rule out other conditions.

Treatment

No medication has proven consistently effective, and most dogs **do not need treatment**.

What you can do

- Stay calm and reassure your dog
- **Distract** with a treat, toy or command
- Look for and avoid triggers
- Watch for any new or different neurological signs, and tell us if they appear

Outlook — excellent

- The tremors do not affect quality of life
- More than half of dogs eventually **stop having episodes** on their own